Do prompts or recasts work better as corrective feedback for second language speaking, and is immediate or delayed feedback more effective?

Prompts elicit greater uptake, while feedback timing depends on individual cognitive factors.

Are prompts more effective than recasts for second language speaking? N = 6

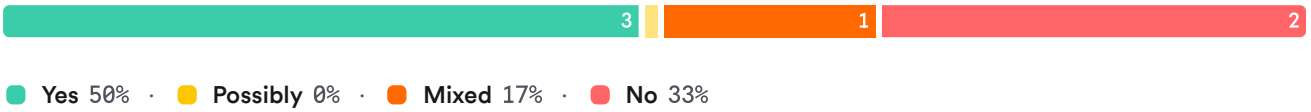


FIGURE 1 Scientific consensus on the comparative effectiveness of prompts versus recasts

Second language research addresses corrective feedback effectiveness across two primary dimensions: the feedback mechanism (prompts versus recasts) and the feedback timing (immediate versus delayed).

Prompts Versus Recasts

Prompts demand that learners actively self-correct, which systematically promotes higher immediate repair rates and enhances grammatical accuracy among lower-proficiency speakers (Alzi'abi, 2026; Ito, 2021; Ammar & Spada, 2006). Recasts provide target-like reformulations without interrupting communicative flow, though learners frequently perceive them as conversational confirmations rather than linguistic corrections (Alzi'abi, 2026; Van Ha et al., 2021; Kamelabad et al., 2026).

- Prompts elicit **significantly higher uptake** and repair rates than recasts across grammatical categories (Alzi'abi, 2026; Ito, 2021).
- Recasts rely on **higher learner proficiency** or explicit metacognitive instruction to achieve durable accuracy (Ammar & Spada, 2006; Sato & Loewen, 2018; Ammar, 2008).
- Prompts improve **spontaneous oral production**, whereas recasts primarily assist controlled pronunciation and salient irregular forms (Sato & Loewen, 2018; Li & Iwashita, 2019; Öztürk, 2023; Gooch et al., 2016).

Immediate Versus Delayed Timing

Feedback timing research yields mixed findings: immediate correction facilitates direct cognitive comparison between errors and target forms, whereas delayed feedback avoids overloading working memory and prevents conversational disruption (Fu & Li, 2020; Rassaei, 2023; Van Ha et al., 2021). Immediate feedback is often preferred by students and proves effective when working memory capacity is sufficient (Rassaei, 2023; Van Ha et al., 2021; Rassaei, 2023). Conversely, delayed feedback shields anxious learners from public embarrassment while delivering comparable or superior gains in specialized oral tasks (Rassaei, 2023; Van Ha et al., 2021; Öztürk, 2023).

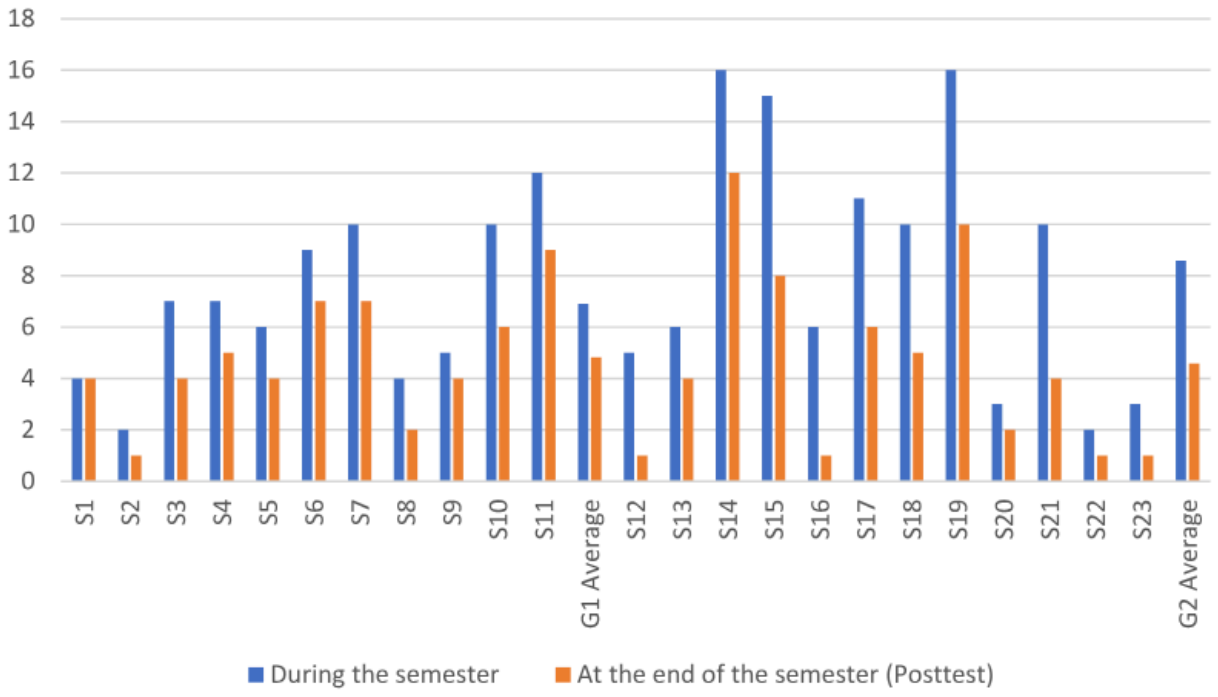


Figure 2. Individual variation in pronunciation errors and group averages (Öztürk, 2023)
How to read: The plot illustrates individual student changes and overall group mean trends in pronunciation errors across an intervention period. Lower values reflect fewer spoken errors.

- Immediate feedback **facilitates cognitive comparison** but depends heavily on individual working memory capacity (Rassaei, 2023).
- Delayed feedback **reduces cognitive burden**, enabling highly anxious learners to process formal corrections effectively (Rassaei, 2023; Fu & Li, 2023).
- Interim task-interval timing **balances cognitive load** and matches immediate feedback for explicit rule learning (Li et al., 2025).

Comparative Evidence Across Studies

Dimension	Feedback Variant	Primary Mechanism	Relative Advantages	Key Caveat
Strategy	Prompts (Alzi'abi, 2026; Ito, 2021)	Output push & self-repair (Alzi'abi, 2026; Ammar, 2008)	High **immediate uptake**; supports beginners (Alzi'abi, 2026; Ammar & Spada, 2006)	Does not supply novel target input (Lyster et al., 2012; Van Ha et al., 2021)
Strategy	Recasts (Brown, 2016; Ammar, 2008)	Implicit positive modeling (Ammar, 2008; Kamelabad et al., 2026)	Preserves **communicative flow**; aids phonetics (Canals et al., 2021; Gooch et al., 2016)	Frequently perceived as conversational approval (Alzi'abi, 2026; Van Ha et al., 2021)

Dimension	Feedback Variant	Primary Mechanism	Relative Advantages	Key Caveat
Timing	Immediate (Li et al., 2025; Kamelabad et al., 2026)	Direct juxtaposition (Fu & Li, 2020; Rassaei, 2023)	Prevents **error proceduralization** (Fu & Li, 2020)	Impairs performance under high anxiety (Rassaei, 2023; Van Ha et al., 2021)
Timing	Delayed (Li et al., 2025; Kamelabad et al., 2026)	Post-task reflection (Rassaei, 2023)	Protects **working memory**; lowers stress (Rassaei, 2023)	Learners may forget target context (Van Ha et al., 2021)

FIGURE 2 Comparison of corrective feedback strategies and timing dimensions in second language speaking

In synthesis, prompts are generally more effective than recasts for eliciting active self-repair and establishing grammatical accuracy among emerging learners (Alzi'abi, 2026; Ammar & Spada, 2006; Ammar, 2008). Meanwhile, the ideal timing between immediate and delayed feedback depends on individual working memory capacity, learner anxiety, and the specific communicative demands of the task (Rassaei, 2023; Fu & Li, 2023; Rassaei, 2023).

These search results were found and analyzed using Consensus, an AI-powered search engine for research. Try it at https://consensus.app. © 2026 Consensus NLP, Inc. Personal, non-commercial use only; redistribution requires copyright holders' consent.

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